

Excepts¹, partial or entire,
Of the Kneeling Prayers
From Vespers on the Evening of Pentecost

Useful for private prayer:

- For supplication and intercession for the living
- For supplication and intercession for the dead and those in Hades
- In the evening

This text may also be used for catechesis. There are extensive endnotes for this purpose.

This document is at:

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost-for-personal-prayer.doc>

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The following document is a “booklet”. Print it double-sided, flipping the pages on the short edge.

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The full text of the Prayers is at:

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Explanation of the “Kneeling Prayers”.

The service on the evening of Pentecost, called “Kneeling Vespers,” is among the most unique of all of our Orthodox Christian services. If somebody asks you how Orthodoxy is different than Roman Catholics or Baptists or whomever, one of the answers could be, “Come to the service of the “Kneeling Prayers” and tell me if you’ve ever experienced anything like it!”

I have always thought it was a shame that these prayers are said only once a year, so I created a booklet of them and generally recite them from Pentecost all the way through the feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul, which follows a week and a day after Pentecost. I recommend that you say them frequently either during the fast, as I do, or throughout the year, as I sometimes have done also.

Get in the habit of excerpting portions of the services that really touch your soul and using them in your private prayers.

Being present in our services is absolutely necessary for the soul, but the soul experiences the services much more profoundly when we also read them and pray the prayers of the services outside of the church. It is not possible to fully absorb the profound spiritual feelings in the kneeling prayers while we are on our knees, especially when people (*and we!*) are fidgeting. With all my heart, I beg you to read these prayers and

use them in your daily prayers, at least for a little while.

They break into three themes. Therefore I have arranged them in three categories: those of “Intercession For The Living” and, of course for ourselves, “Prayers for the Dead”, which are unspeakably profound and beautiful, and “Evening Prayers” since of course we are serving Vespers in the evening which is the beginning of the day liturgically and the end of the day biologically.

These prayers will answer many questions if you will pray them with attention and with compunction.

One of the questions people have is about praying for the dead, or rather, there are many questions, almost like a hydra with many heads. I’m a simple man, and therefore I think all these questions really are just distractions.

Our God is love, and He is merciful, and therefore we are to love and to be merciful. And our God remembers everything and everyone. Therefore, we remember everyone whether they are living or dead, and we love everyone whether they are living or dead, and we pray to God for everyone whether they are living or dead, and believe that He is merciful to everyone, both the living and the dead. We do not need to have a deep understanding of exactly what’s happening for the dead, just as a child does not need to have a deep

understanding of theology to know that his guardian angel protects him!

Of course, when we speak of people being dead, we know that they are still alive, since our Lord Jesus Christ emphatically told us that He is the God of the living, not the dead! *“But that the dead are raised, even Moses indicated in the passage concerning the bush where the Lord saith, ‘I am the God of Abraham, and the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob.’ “Now He is not the God of the dead, but of the living; for all live to Him.” (Luke 20:37,38).*

Since those with bodies that are dead or even have completely decayed are among the living because their souls are alive, we pray for them with expectation, and humility, and love. Read these prayers carefully, and then ask yourself if you truly love someone who has died *if you never remember them in prayer.*

In my experience, because of the wretched toxins of the West, many people, even among the Orthodox are not so sure about prayer for the dead. The Lord told us that we should become like children! So just be a child and believe that God is good, and that He loves, and that we should love, and He remembers, and that we should remember, and remember that God is the God of the living not of the dead. And, since the church prays for the dead throughout the entire year, and has special days that are set apart to pray for the dead, including every Saturday, just do what the church does. It's really as simple as that. Set

some of your vaunted intellect aside, and just follow the example of the church. It's a much simpler way, and your soul will be filled with God, because God comes to the humble.

The Vespers service on the evening of Pentecost, in parish practice, and usually in our practice, is served very early in the afternoon, because otherwise people will leave and they will not experience its profound grace. In the monastery, it would likely be served at the usual evening time. It begins like any other Vespers service, all the way through the small entrance and the prokeimenon. The priest then exits the altar through the Royal doors and begins the first of the kneeling prayers.

They are prayed in three sets, with portions of the Vespers service interspersed in between. We pray them on our knees. For some, this means prostrating themselves on the floor with their forehead touching the ground, while for others, it means standing on their knees. And for the children, it means that they are wiggling around and occasionally looking up and around the room, and maybe even catching the eye of their Papa! I always pray them standing on my knees because it's much easier to read the text and for the church to hear it, because if I'm prostrated all the way on the ground, since I'm an old fat man, it's really hard for me to have the text far enough away from my eyes to be able to read it. There are seven prayers in total dispersed over three segments. The first set is two prayers, and the second also two, and the

third, which is very long, contains three prayers.

This booklet does not present the prayers in the exact order in which they are read during Vespers. And there are changes made to the prayers, not to change their meaning, but to change the tenses of the words and to not refer to them as we occurring on the very day of Pentecost. I changed the order because it breaks down into three categories. For instance, the first and second sets of prayers contain a general intercession for everyone living, and then a prayer for the evening. The last set of prayers concentrates on prayer for the dead, and also has an evening prayer. The prayers in this booklet are grouped so that you could say some prayers in the morning, and some in the evening. You can pray for the dead anytime you want. I always pray for them in the morning.

What should we notice about these prayers? Here is a non-inclusive list for your consideration.

1. The prayers are deeply compunctionate, and we who are not very compunctionate are trying to say them compunctionately.
2. The prayers are deeply theological, and even reciting these theological concepts

without a full understanding increases our compunction and awe. We who are Orthodox do not say simple prayers in church! We also teach theology in almost every prayer. That must mean that theology is really important. It's important to understand about God and to apply this understanding to becoming like God.

3. The prayers are deeply introspective, and realistic about who we are and who God is. Therefore, we blame ourselves, and we hope in God. Drink deeply the "mindset" of these prayers. Many of our prayers say terrible things about ourselves, but they are very hopeful and full of joyful energy. You will learn this energy as you continue to say the prayers and you continue to struggle to live a Christian life, falling down and getting back up, and changing for the better.
4. The prayers for the dead are detailed and hopeful, and in any soul that reads them with attention, they give us energy! They will give you some insight into the condition of the dead, but mostly, they will give you the energy to remember the dead as much as you remember the living and remember that you are going to be dead some time.

Priest Seraphim Holland. Pentecost, 2025

shalt thou have hope. With a shield will His truth encompass thee;
90:5 thou shalt not be afraid for the terror by night, nor for the arrow that flieth by day, 90:6 Nor for the thing that walketh in darkness, nor for the mishap and demon of noonday.

⁶⁰ Gen 1:1-5 In the beginning God made the heaven and the earth. (2) But the earth was unsightly and unfurnished, and darkness was over the deep, and the Spirit of God moved over the water. (3) And God said, Let there be light, and there was light. (4) And God saw the light that it was good, and God divided between the light and the darkness. (5) And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night, and there was evening and there was morning, the first day.

⁶¹ The original phrase was : "as a good and man-loving God, "

⁵³ 1Th 4:13-18 But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. (14) For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him. (15) For this we say unto you by the word of the Lord, that we which are alive *and* remain unto the coming of the Lord shall not prevent them which are asleep. (16) For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: (17) Then we which are alive *and* remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord. (18) Wherefore comfort one another with these words.

⁵⁴ We emphatically dogmatize that the human nature of Jesus Christ is exactly that of all human beings. Because, at conception, his human nature was completely overshadowed by the Holy Spirit, he was fully anointed with the Holy Spirit, which is the reason we call him "Christ". "Christ" means "anointed".

⁵⁵ The unavoidable passions are the so-called "blameless passions" which Christ shared with us because of his human nature. These are things like the need for sleep, the need to eat, getting thirsty, etc.

⁵⁶ Hebrews who2:16 For verily he took not on *him the nature of angels*; but he took on *him* the seed of Abraham.

Heb 2:17 Wherefore in all things it behoved him to be made like unto *his* brethren, that he might be a merciful and faithful high priest in things *pertaining* to God, to make reconciliation for the sins of the people. **Heb 2:18** For in that he himself hath suffered being tempted, he is able to succour them that are tempted.

Heb 4:14-16 Seeing then that we have a great high priest, that is passed into the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast *our* profession. (15) For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as *we are*, yet without sin (16) Let us therefore come boldly unto the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy, and find grace to help in time of need.

⁵⁷ Rom 3:23 For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God;

⁵⁸ Exclamation not in the original prayer.

⁵⁹ Psalm 90:1 He that dwelleth in the help of the Most High shall abide in the shelter of the God of heaven. 90:2 He shall say unto the Lord: Thou art my helper and my refuge. He is my God, and I will hope in Him. 90:3 For He shall deliver thee from the snare of the hunters and from every troubling word. 90:4 With His shoulders will He overshadow thee, and under His wings

Intercessory prayers for the Living.

A Prayer of Intercession for All People. From Kneeling Prayer 1.1.

O Most-pure², spotless, unoriginate,
invisible, incomprehensible,
unsearchable, immutable, invincible,
immeasurable, forbearing Lord,

Who alone hast immortality³,

Who dwellest in light unapproachable⁴,
Who hast made heaven and earth and
sea, and all that is therein,

Who unto all grantest their petitions
before they ask:⁵

We pray Thee, and we ask Thee, O
Master, Lover of mankind, the Father of
our Lord and God and Saviour Jesus
Christ,

Who for us men and for our salvation,
came down from the heavens and was
incarnate of the Holy Spirit and the Ever-
virgin Mary, the most glorious
Theotokos;⁶

Who, having first taught in words, and
afterward instructed by deed⁷, when He
had endured the saving Passion, granted
unto us, Thy lowly and sinful and
unworthy servants a precept that we
should offer prayers unto Thee, with

bowing of the neck and knees, for our
own sins, and for the errors of the
people.⁸

Do Thou Thyself, O Plenteously Merciful
One and Lover of mankind, hearken unto
us *on this* day when we call upon Thee,
as we did on the day of Pentecost⁹,

whereon after the Ascension of our
Lord Jesus Christ into the heavens, and
His sitting at the right hand of Thee, God
and the Father, He sent down upon His
holy disciples and apostles the Holy
Spirit, Who rested upon each of them,
and all were filled with His inexhaustible
grace, and spake in other tongues of Thy
greatness and did prophesy.¹⁰

Now, therefore, do Thou hearken unto
us who pray unto Thee, and remember
us the lowly and condemned, and turn
again the captivity of our souls, having
Thy loving-kindness interceding for us.

Accept us who fall down before Thee
and shout: We have sinned; on Thee
were we cast from the womb, from our
mother's womb, Thou art our God.¹¹

But inasmuch as our days were consumed in vanity, we were bereft of Thy help, we deprived ourselves of any defense;

but presuming upon Thy compassions, we cry: The sins of our youth and ignorances remember not, and from our secret sins cleanse us¹², and cast us not away in the time of our old age, when our strength faileth;

forsake us not even until we return again into the earth,

vouchsafe us to return unto Thee;

attend to us through Thy good favour, and grace;

measure our transgressions with Thy compassions,

set the abyss of Thy compassions against the multitude of our sins.¹³

Look down from Thy holy height, O Lord, upon Thy people standing before Thee and looking for abundant mercies from Thee.

Visit us with Thy goodness, deliver us from the assaults of the devil;¹⁴

establish our life upon Thy holy and sacred commandments.

Commit Thy people unto a faithful guardian angel,

gather all into Thy kingdom,

grant pardon unto them that hope in Thee;

remit their sins and ours.

Cleanse us by the working of Thy Holy Spirit; destroy the wiles of the enemy directed against us.

[A Prayer of Supplication & Intercession for All People. From Kneeling Prayer 2.1.](#)

O Lord Jesus Christ our God, Who hast bestowed upon men Thy peace¹⁵, and the gift of the Holy Spirit;

Who, while still on earth and present with us, didst grant an inalienable

inheritance to the faithful, but more visibly hast sent down grace *on the day of Pentecost*¹⁶ upon Thy disciples and apostles, and hast strengthened their lips with fiery tongues,

O God of spirits and of all flesh, Who hast trampled down death, and overthrown the devil, and given life to Thy world: Do Thou Thyself, O Lord, give rest to the souls of Thy departed servants, N.N., in a place of light, a place of green pasture, a place of repose, whence all sickness, sorrow and sighing are fled away. Pardon every sin committed by them in word, deed, or thought, in that Thou art a good God, the Lover of mankind; for there is no man that liveth and sinneth not, for Thou alone art without sin, Thy righteousness is an everlasting righteousness, and Thy word is truth.

Exclamation: For Thou art the Resurrection, and the life, and the repose of the Thy departed servant(s), (N.N) O Christ our God, and unto Thee do we send up glory, together with Thine unoriginate Father, and Thy most holy and good and life-creating Spirit, now and ever, and unto the ages of ages

⁴⁹ Psalm 113:25 Not the dead shall praise Thee, O Lord, nor any that go down to hades. 113:26 But we the living will bless the Lord from henceforth and for evermore

⁵⁰ A doxology is a hymn of praise. The quintessential Trinitarian, that is, "thrice-holy" doxology is the "Trisagion": "Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, have mercy on us."

⁵¹ Psalm 50:2 Wash me thoroughly from mine iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin.

Psalm 50:9 Turn Thy face away from my sins, and blot out all mine iniquities.

⁵² At the second coming of Christ, we will be reunited to our bodies which will be perfected along with perfected souls. Everyone will be resurrected in their body and soul rejoined, even the wicked.

1Co 15:51-58 Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, (52) In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump: for the trumpet shall sound, and the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. (53) For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal *must* put on immortality. (54) So when this corruptible shall have put on incorruption, and this mortal shall have put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written, Death is swallowed up in victory. (55) O death, where *is* thy sting? O grave, where *is* thy victory? (56) The sting of death *is* sin; and the strength of sin *is* the law. (57) But thanks *be* to God, which giveth us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. (58) Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye stedfast, unmoveable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord.

Joh 5:28-29 Marvel not at this: for the hour is coming, in the which all that are in the graves shall hear his voice, (29) And shall come forth; they that have done good, unto the resurrection of life; and they that have done evil, unto the resurrection of damnation.

⁴⁰ The Symbol of faith says "Light of light , true God of true God, begotten not made, of one essence with the Father..."

⁴¹ The omitted words are: "of whom we make commemoration now,"

⁴² At this point in time, the immortal race is the Angels, and the mortal race is mankind since our bodies will die, and we will be truly immortal when our bodies are reconstituted in perfection and rejoin with our soul in perfection

⁴³ Psalm 38:4 O Lord, make me to know mine end, and the number of my days, what it is, that I may know what I lack. 38:5 Behold, Thou hast made my days as the spans of a hand, and my being is as nothing before Thee. Nay, all things are vanity, every man living.

⁴⁴ At the time this was written, everyone who died went to Hades because Hades was a holding place for the dead. No one could escape Hades because no man had the strength, since the son of God had not yet become incarnated and been crucified and defeated death in Hades. At this present time, some go to Hades, and some go to paradise. Technically speaking, there is no Gehenna or Hell right now, nor is there heaven exactly, because with the exception of the Theotokos, none of those who have died as mortals have bodies. But we will have bodies and then, perhaps by the mercy of God, many will be brought out of Hades with perfected bodies enjoying heaven with the righteous. This is what we are praying for.

⁴⁵ The original prayer, instead of "*the*" says "this last and"

⁴⁶ Original prayer: "Who also on this all-perfect and saving feast" changed to: "Who also on *the* all-perfect and saving feast of *Pentecost*"

⁴⁷ Let us be careful to understand this prayer in the context of Christian "hope.". Hope is not wishing. Hope is waiting with expectation for something to me we know will come to pass. We know that some will be saved out of Hades. We don't know or how many we know that some will be saved and therefore we pray with hope.

⁴⁸ These two sentences should be very familiar to everyone, as they are used in all memorial services. If they are not familiar to you, then you are either very new to the faith or don't attend church often is enough. It is useful to say this prayer for everyone, every day. I have the perhaps somewhat controversial opinion that it can be prayed for anyone in your private prayers because it doesn't specifically mention that a person is Orthodox or not. Our custom is not to pray for non-Orthodox in church services but we pray for everyone privately whether Orthodox or not, irreligious, atheists, good or bad, or suicides, or any other human condition. Here is the prayer:

whereby we, together with the whole race of mankind, having received the knowledge of God in their own tongues¹⁷ in the hearing of our own ears,

have been enlightened by the light of the Spirit, and have been changed from delusion as from out of darkness¹⁸,

and through the distribution of the material and fiery tongues,

and the supernatural activity were taught to believe in Thee,

and kindled to bless Thee together with the Father and the Holy Spirit, in one Godhead and might and authority:

Do Thou, O Effulgence of the Father, immutable and immovable Image of His essence and nature¹⁹, the Fountain of wisdom and grace,

open the lips of even me a sinner and teach me how I ought to pray and what needs to pray for;²⁰

for Thou knowest the great multitude of my sins,

but Thy loving-kindness will overcome their immensity.²¹

For, behold, in fear I stand before Thee, having cast the despair of my soul into the abyss of Thy mercy:²²

do Thou pilot my life, O Thou Who by a word dost direct all creation by the unutterable might of Thy wisdom,

O peaceful Haven of the storm-tossed, and cause me to know the way wherein I should walk.²³

Grant unto my thoughts the Spirit of Thy wisdom,

bestowing upon my foolishness the Spirit of understanding;²⁴

overshadow my doings with the spirit of Thy fear,

and renew a right spirit within me, and with Thy governing Spirit establish my sliding thoughts;²⁵

so that being daily guided by Thy good Spirit in things profitable,

I may be enabled to keep Thy commandments, and ever to bear in mind Thy glorious Coming,

and those things worthy of torment that we have done.

And do not suffer me to be captivated by the corruptible beauties of this world,

but strengthen me in the desire to attain the treasures of the world to come.

For Thou hast said, O Master, that whatsoever one may ask in Thy name, he shall freely receive it from Thine ever-existing God and Father.²⁶

Wherefore, I also, a sinner, ... entreat Thy goodness to grant me whatsoever I have asked which is unto salvation²⁷.

Yea, O Lord, abundant Giver of every benefit,

Bestower of good things,
for Thou it is Who dost most abundantly grant that which we request;

Thou art compassionate and merciful, having without sin been a participant in our flesh,²⁸

and in Thy compassionate loving-kindness art inclined toward those that bow the knee before Thee,

having been the propitiation for our sins.

Grant then, O Lord, Thy compassions unto Thy people;

hearken unto us out of Thy holy heaven; sanctify us with the might of Thy saving right hand;

shelter us with the shelter of Thy wings, and disdain not the work of Thy hands.

Against Thee only have we sinned, but also Thee only do we serve.

We know not how to worship an alien god, nor to stretch out our hands, O Master, to another god.²⁹

Forgive us our sins, and having accepted our supplications, *which we first made on bended knees, on Pentecost.*³⁰

stretch out unto us all a helping hand; receive the prayer of all as pleasing incense, acceptable before Thy most blessed kingdom.

and may fill their treasures with good things. If I declare to you the things that daily happen, I will remember also to recount the things of old. **(22) The Lord made me the beginning of his ways for his works. (23) He established me before time was in the beginning, before he made the earth: (24) even before he made the depths; before the fountains of water came forth: (25) before the mountains were settled, and before all hills, he begets me.** (26) The Lord made countries and uninhabited tracks, and the highest inhabited parts of the world. (27) When he prepared the heaven, I was present with him; and when he prepared his throne upon the winds: (28) and when he strengthened the clouds above; and when he secured the fountains of the earth: (29) and when he strengthened the foundations of the earth: (30) I was by him, suiting myself to him, I was that wherein he took delight; and daily I rejoiced in his presence continually. (31) For he rejoiced when he had completed the world, and rejoiced among the children of men. (32) Now then, my son, hear me: blessed is the man who shall hearken to me, and the mortal who shall keep my ways; (34) watching daily at my doors, waiting at the posts of my entrances. (35) For my outgoings are the outgoings of life, and in them is prepared favour from the Lord. (36) But they that sin against me act wickedly against their own souls: and they that hate me love death.

³⁹ Mat 4:12-17 Now when Jesus had heard that John was cast into prison, he departed into Galilee; (13) And leaving Nazareth, he came and dwelt in Capernaum, which is upon the sea coast, in the borders of Zabulon and Nephtholim: (14) That it might be fulfilled which was spoken by Esaias the prophet, saying, (15) The land of Zabulon, and the land of Nephtholim, by the way of the sea, beyond Jordan, Galilee of the Gentiles; (16) The people which sat in darkness saw great light; and to them which sat in the region and shadow of death light is sprung Up. (17) From that time Jesus began to preach, and to say, Repent: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.

Isa 42:6-7 I the LORD have called thee in righteousness, and will hold thine hand, and will keep thee, and give thee for a covenant of the people, for a light of the Gentiles; (7) To open the blind eyes, to bring out the prisoners from the prison, *and* them that sit in darkness out of the prison house.

Luk 1:76-79 And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways; (77) To give knowledge of salvation unto his people by the remission of their sins, (78) Through the tender mercy of our God; whereby the dayspring from on high hath visited us, (79) To give light to them that sit in darkness and *in* the shadow of death, to guide our feet into the way of peace. (From the song of Zechariah)

who were righteous awaited release from Hades with great expectation and longing, and those who were not righteous in a certain sense of dread.

At this time, Hades still exists, but the doors have been broken. It is not a foregone conclusion that the soul will go to Hades after death. The righteous go to paradise, and those who are not righteous go to Hades to await the judgment. We have many examples in our tradition that show that it is possible for those who are in Hades to be released because of the prayers of the righteous

³⁷ At this in point in time, hell, or Gehenna is not in existence. The prayer is speaking of future time when Satan will be fully bound. Of course right now, he is free to run the earth as a roaring lion seeking whom he will devour.

One must be careful with translations. Unfortunately there are many translations in English which translate the Greek word for Hades incorrectly, calling it hell.

³⁸ Many times, when wisdom is personified, the person being referred to is Jesus Christ. For example:

Proverbs 8:1-36 Thou shalt proclaim wisdom, that understanding may be obedient to thee. (2) For she is on lofty eminences, and stands in the midst of the ways. (3) For she sits by the gates of princes, and sings in the entrances, saying, (4) You, O men, I exhort; and utter my voice to the sons of men. (5) O ye simple, understand subtlety, and ye that are untaught, imbibe knowledge. (6) Harken to me; for I will speak solemn truths; and will produce right sayings from my lips. (7) For my throat shall meditate truth; and false lips are an abomination before me. (8) All the words of my mouth are in righteousness; there is nothing in them wrong or perverse. (9) They are all evident to those that understand, and right to those that find knowledge. (10) Receive instruction, and not silver; and knowledge rather than tried gold. (11) For wisdom is better than precious stones; and no valuable substance is of equal worth with it. (12) I wisdom have dwelt with counsel and knowledge, and I have called upon understanding. (13) The fear of the Lord hates unrighteousness, and insolence, and pride, and the ways of wicked men; and I hate the perverse ways of bad men. (14) Counsel and safety are mine; prudence is mine, and strength is mine. (15) By me kings reign, and princes decree justice. (16) By me nobles become great, and monarchs by me rule over the earth. (17) I love those that love me; and they that seek me shall find me. (18) Wealth and glory belong to me; yea, abundant possessions and righteousness. (19) It is better to have my fruit than to have gold and precious stones; and my produce is better than choice silver. (20) I walk in ways of righteousness, and am conversant with the paths of judgment; (21) that I may divide substance to them that love me,

O Ever-flowing, living, and Illumining Fountain,³¹

O Might creative, co-ever-existing³² with the Father,

Who hast most excellently fulfilled the whole economy concerning the salvation³³ of mankind, O Christ our God;

Who hast shattered the indestructible chains of death and the bolts of hades, and hast trampled down a multitude of evil spirits;³⁴

Who hast given Thyself for us as a blameless offering,³⁵ and given Thy most pure Body in sacrifice, inviolable and inaccessible for any sin,

and through this terrible and ineffable sacred act granted us life eternal;

Who hast descended into hades and broken the eternal bars, and showed the way up, to those that sat in darkness; Who with divinely-wise allurements hast caught the origin of evil and the serpent of the abyss,³⁶

and having bound him with the chains of darkness in Tartarus and unquenchable fire,³⁷

and having confined him in outer darkness by Thy boundless might,

O pre-eminent Wisdom³⁸ of the Father, Thou hast appeared as a great Helper unto the unfortunate,

and hast enlightened those sitting in darkness and the shadow of death.³⁹

Do Thou, O Lord of everlasting glory, beloved Son of the Father Most High,

Light ever-existing of Light ever-existing⁴⁰,

Sun of righteousness:

Hearken unto us that pray unto Thee, and grant rest to the souls of Thy servants,

Our fathers and brethren departed before us,

and the rest of our kindred according to the flesh, and all our fellow-believers,

...⁴¹ for Thou hast dominion over all, and upholdest in Thy hand all the ends of the earth.

O Master Almighty, God of the fathers and Lord of Mercy,

Creator of both the mortal and immortal race,⁴²

and of all the nature of man;

of that which cometh into being, and again passeth away;

of life and death;

of sojourn here, and translation beyond this world;

Thou dost measure out the years unto the living, and appointest the time for death,⁴³

Thou bringest into, and ledest out of, hades,⁴⁴

Thou dost bind in infirmity and loosest in strength;

the present dost Thou arrange according to need,

and the future Thou directest profitably;

those smitten with the sting of death Thou gladdenest with the hope of resurrection.

Do Thou Thyself then, O Master of all, O God our Savior,

Thou hope of all the ends of the earth and of them that be far off at sea,

Who *hast* also on *the*⁴⁵ great and salutary day of the feast of Pentecost shown unto us the mystery of the Holy, consubstantial, co-eternal, indivisible and unmingled Trinity;

and in the coming down and descent didst pour out Thy Holy and life-giving Spirit in the form of tongues of fire upon Thy holy apostles,

and appointed these as evangelists of our pious Faith, showing them to be confessors and proclaimers of the True Theology,

Who also on *the* all-perfect and saving feast of *Pentecost*⁴⁶ hast deigned to receive propitiatory prayers for those that are kept in hades,

giving us great hope that through Thee release and consolation may be sent

gods beside me. (4) Thou shalt not make to thyself an idol, nor likeness of anything, whatever things are in the heaven above, and whatever are in the earth beneath, and whatever are in the waters under the earth. (5) Thou shalt not bow down to them, nor serve them; for I am the Lord thy God, a jealous God, recompensing the sins of the fathers upon the children, to the third and fourth generation to them that hate me, (6) and bestowing mercy on them that love me to thousands of them, and on Them that keep my commandments.

³⁰ Original text is "made on bended knees," Altered text is "*which we first* made on bended knees, on Pentecost"

³¹ We can just as easily and accurately refer to the Holy Spirit, or the Father, or the Holy Trinity as an "ever-flowing fountain." When we describe one of the hypostases of God in a certain way, except when we refer to the exclusive attributes of the Father (that He is the uncaused, eternal cause of the Son and the Holy Spirit, the son being eternally begotten, the Spirit eternally proceeding) we are not making a description unique to that hypostasis.

³² All of the hypostases of the Holy Trinity are "co-existing.: There was never a moment when the Son was not the only-begotten of the Father, of the Spirit proceeded from the Father. All are equally God, that is one in essence. There are heresies which attack this dogma, such as Arianism.

³³ How would we describe the "whole economy of salvation?" This is not a simple or short answer. It involves everything from the time that God made a promise that through Eve would come a redeemer, God selecting the Jews as his peculiar people, the prophets, the progenitors of Christ, the Annunciation and the subsequent incarnation of God so that He would be the God man Jesus Christ, His ministry on the earth with miracles and teaching of the disciples, is trial and death and resurrection, after He destroyed the hold of sin by descending into Hades, his ascension and the subsequent giving of the Holy Spirit, and all the other things that have occurred as the Holy Spirit guides the church.

³⁴ The Pascha Troparion: Christ is risen from the dead, trampling down death by death, and upon those in the tombs bestowing life!"

³⁵ From the Silent Prayer of the priest during the Cherubic Hymn of Divine Liturgy: "For Thou art He that offereth and is offered, that accepteth and is distributed, O Christ our God..."

³⁶ Hades was the place of the dead. Before the resurrection of Christ, who died, whether sinner or righteous, went to Hades. It was not a place of torment per se, but rather a place where the dead were because they could not rise up because of their sins and incompetence. Those

²⁵ Psalm 50:12 Restore unto me the joy of Thy salvation, and with Thy governing Spirit establish me.

²⁶ John 14:13-14 And whatsoever ye shall ask in my name, that will I do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son. (14) If ye shall ask any thing in my name, I will do *it*.

²⁷ Matthew 7:7-11 Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you: (8) For every one that asketh receiveth; and he that seeketh findeth; and to him that knocketh it shall be opened. (9) Or what man is there of you, whom if his son ask bread, will he give him a stone? (10) Or if he ask a fish, will he give him a serpent? (11) If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children, how much more shall your Father which is in heaven give good things to them that ask him?

John 14:13-14 And whatsoever ye shall ask in my name, that will I do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son. (14) If ye shall ask any thing in my name, I will do *it*.

James 4:1-8 From whence *come* wars and fightings among you? *come they* not hence, *even of* your lusts that war in your members? (2) Ye lust, and have not: ye kill, and desire to have, and cannot obtain: ye fight and war, yet ye have not, because ye ask not. (3) Ye ask, and receive not, because ye ask amiss, that ye may consume *it* upon your lusts. (4) Ye adulterers and adulteresses, know ye not that the friendship of the world is enmity with God? whosoever therefore will be a friend of the world is the enemy of God. (5) Do ye think that the scripture saith in vain, The spirit that dwelleth in us lusteth to envy? (6) But he giveth more grace. Wherefore he saith, God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble. (7) Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. (8) Draw nigh to God, and he will draw nigh to you. Cleanse *your* hands, *ye* sinners; and purify *your* hearts, *ye* double minded.

²⁸ Heb 4:14-16 Seeing then that we have a great high priest, that is passed into the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast *our* profession. (15) For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as *we are*, yet without sin. (16) Let us therefore come boldly unto the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy, and find grace to help in time of need.

²⁹ There are many alien “gods”: demons, idols, lust for money, fame, comfort, etc. On the surface, this is a promise to uphold the first two of the 10 commandments:

Exodus 20:1-6 And the Lord spoke all these words, saying: (2) I am the Lord thy God, who brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. (3) Thou shalt have no other

down to those held there in bondage of vileness.⁴⁷

Hearken unto us, Thy lowly servants that pray unto Thee,

and give rest to Thy servants departed before us,

in a place of light, a place of green pasture, in a place of refreshment,

whence all sickness, sorrow, and sighing are fled away;⁴⁸

and commit their souls to the tabernacles of the righteous,

and vouchsafe unto them peace and release;

For not the dead shall praise Thee, O Lord,

nor those that be in hades dare to offer confession to Thee,⁴⁹

but we the living will bless Thee and will pray and bring propitiatory prayers and sacrifices unto Thee for their souls.

A Prayer of Supplication because of our sins and for the dead. From Kneeling Prayer 3.2.

O God great, eternal, and holy, Who lovest mankind and hast vouchsafed us to stand in this very hour before Thine unapproachable glory in song and praise of Thy wonders:

Cleanse us, Thine unworthy servants, and grant us the grace with a broken heart and without pride to offer unto Thee the Thrice-holy Doxology⁵⁰,

And thanksgiving for Thy great gifts, which Thou hast conferred upon us and always conferrest upon us.

Remember, O Lord, our weakness, and destroy us not with our iniquities;⁵¹

but deal with our humility in great mercy, that having escaped the darkness of sin,

we may walk in the day of righteousness, and having put on the armor of light,

we may abide unassailed from all snares of the evil one,

and with boldness glorify Thee, the only true God and Lover of mankind.

For Thine is the truly and really great mystery, O Master and Maker of all,

temporary dissolution of Thy creatures,
and thereafter their re-integration and
repose unto the ages,⁵²

we acknowledge Thy grace in
everything, for our coming into this
world,

and our departure, our hope of
resurrection and life incorruptible,
faithfully pledged unto us through thy
promise,

which we shall receive in the future at
Thy Second Coming.⁵³

For Thou art also the Author of our
resurrection and the incorruptible and
man-loving Judge of those who have
lived,

and the Master and Lord of rewards,
Who also wast joined unto us equally in
flesh and blood,⁵⁴

because of Thine extreme
condescension;

and when by Thine own will Thou didst
place Thyself under temptation, and in
Thy tender compassion didst take our
unavoidable passions⁵⁵,

and having thereby suffered
temptation,

Thou art become for us who are
tempted the Helper which Thou Thyself
hadst promised,⁵⁶

wherefore, also Thou hast led us unto
Thy passionlessness.

Accept, therefore, O Master, our
prayers and supplications,

and give rest unto all the fathers and
mothers and children and the brothers
and sisters and relatives of each one of
us,

and all the souls gone to their rest
before us;

and commit their spirits unto the hope
of resurrection unto life eternal,

and inscribe their names in the Book of
Life,

in the bosom of Abraham, and Isaac,
and Jacob,

in the land of the living,

in the Kingdom of Heaven,

in the Paradise of delight,

by Thy radiant angels bringing all into
Thy holy habitations,

²⁰ now here's a humble prayer! We have no idea what we need. We think we know what we need but we are often living in delusion. It is better to tell the Lord to give us what we need and even to tell us how to ask for the things that we really need

²¹ Another beautiful example the mindset of orthodox prayer. We acknowledge our great sinfulness and in the same breath have great certainty that the Lord will help us

²² Read that again!

²³ Psalm 142:7 Quickly hear me, O Lord; my spirit hath fainted away. Turn not Thy face away from me, lest I be like unto them that go down into the pit.

142:8 Cause me to hear Thy mercy in the morning; for in Thee have I put my hope. Cause me to know, O Lord, the way wherein I should walk; for unto Thee have I lifted up my soul.

142:9 Rescue me from mine enemies, O Lord; unto Thee have I fled for refuge.

142:10 Teach me to do Thy will, for Thou art my God. Thy good Spirit shall lead me in the land of uprightness;

142:11 for Thy name's sake, O Lord, shalt Thou quicken me. In Thy righteousness shalt Thou bring my soul out of affliction,

142:12 and in Thy mercy shalt Thou utterly destroy mine enemies. And Thou shalt cut off all them that afflict my soul, for I am Thy servant.

²⁴ Isaiah 11:1 And there shall come forth a rod out of the root of Jesse, and a blossom shall come up from his root: 2 and the Spirit of God shall rest upon him,

[1] the spirit of wisdom

[2] and understanding,

[3] the spirit of counsel

[4] and strength (fortitude),

[5] the spirit of knowledge

[6] and godliness (piety) shall fill him;

[7] 3 the spirit of the fear of God.

He shall not judge according to appearance, nor reprove according to report: 4 but he shall judge the cause of the lowly, and shall reprove the lowly of the earth: and he shall smite the earth with the word of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips shall he destroy the ungodly one. 5 And he shall have his loins girt with righteousness, and his sides clothed with truth. (Isaiah 11:1-7)

Joh_14:27 Peace I leave with you, my peace I give unto you: not as the world giveth, give I unto you. Let not your heart be troubled, neither let it be afraid.

Joh_16:33 These things I have spoken unto you, that in me ye might have peace. In the world ye shall have tribulation: but be of good cheer; I have overcome the world.

_John 19:20:-21 Then the same day at evening, being the first day of the week, when the doors were shut where the disciples were assembled for fear of the Jews, came Jesus and stood in the midst, and saith unto them, Peace be unto you.²¹ Then said Jesus to them again, Peace be unto you: as my Father hath sent me, even so send I you.

Act_10:36 The word which God sent unto the children of Israel, preaching peace by Jesus Christ: (he is Lord of all:)

16 Prayer says : “this grace today “

17 The gift of tongues was a gift of being understandable to those who understood many tongues. The Apostles spoke in their tongue, and the recipients understood in their tongue.

¹⁸ What an idea! A true idea and godly idea. The understanding that we are in darkness and only by God can be brought up be brought out of darkness since He is like. Imagine if we completely believed this how little we would lean on our own understanding!

¹⁹ “Heb 1:1-8 God, who at sundry times and in divers manners spake in time past unto the fathers by the prophets, (2) Hath in these last days spoken unto us by *his* Son, whom he hath appointed heir of all things, by whom also he made the worlds; (3) Who being the brightness Up (effulgence) of *his* glory, and the express image of his person, and upholding all things by the word of his power, when he had by himself purged our sins, sat down on the right hand of the Majesty on high; (4) Being made so much better than the angels, as he hath by inheritance obtained a more excellent name than they. (5) For unto which of the angels said he at any time, Thou art my Son, this day have I begotten thee? And again, I will be to him a Father, and he shall be to me a Son? (6) And again, when he bringeth in the first begotten into the world, he saith, And let all the angels of God worship him. (7) And of the angels he saith, Who maketh his angels spirits, and his ministers a flame of fire. (8) But unto the Son *he saith*, Thy throne, O God, *is* for ever and ever: a sceptre of righteousness *is* the sceptre of thy kingdom.”

and raising up also our bodies in the day which Thou hast appointed according to Thy holy and sure promise.

There is, therefore, O Lord, no death for Thy servants, when we leave the body and come unto Thee, our God,

But a transition from things most saddening unto things most beneficial and most delightful, and unto repose and joy.

And though we have sinned against Thee,

be Thou merciful unto us and them, for there is no one free from stain in Thy sight,⁵⁷

even if his life be but one day, unless it be Thou alone, Who didst manifest Thyself sinless upon the earth, O our Lord Jesus Christ;

of Whom we all hope to obtain mercy and remission of sins.

Therefore, both unto us and them do Thou,

as a good and man-loving God, loose, remit, and pardon our transgressions,

voluntary and involuntary, whether in knowledge or in ignorance, manifest and forgotten, whether in deed or thought or word, in all our lives and ways.

And unto the departed then, grant Thou freedom and release, and bless us that remain here, granting a good and peaceful end unto us and unto all Thy people,

and the bowels of mercy and love for mankind do Thou open unto us, at Thy terrible and dread Coming, and make us worthy of Thy kingdom,

For we glorify thee, a good and man-loving God, and unto Thee do we send up glory, to the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit, Amen⁵⁸.

An Evening Prayer. From Kneeling Prayer 1.2.

Blessed art Thou, O Lord, Master Almighty,	and Thy compassions upon Thine inheritance.
Who didst illumine the day with the light of the sun,	Defend us with Thy holy angels,
and makest the night clear with fiery redness,	arm us with the weapon of Thy righteousness;
Who hast vouchsafed us to pass through the length of the day,	compass us about with Thy truth,
and to approach the beginning of the night:	keep us by Thy might,
Hearken unto our supplications, and those of all Thy people,	deliver us from every attack, every plot laid by the adversary.
forgiving us all our sins, voluntary and involuntary.	Grant unto us that this evening, with the approaching night,
Accept our evening supplications,	and all the days of our life,
and send down a multitude of Thy mercies,	may be perfect, holy, peaceful, sinless, without temptations, undisturbed;
	through the intercessions of the holy Theotokos, and of all the saints who from the ages have been pleasing to Thee.

An Evening Prayer of Supplication & Intercession. From Kneeling Prayer 2.2.

O Lord, O Lord, Who hast delivered us from every arrow that flieth by day ⁵⁹ ,	deliver us also from everything that walketh in darkness.
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Luke 1:68-79 Blessed be the Lord God of Israel; for he hath visited and redeemed his people, (69) And hath raised up an horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David; (70) As he spake by the mouth of his holy prophets, which have been since the world began: (71) That we should be saved from our enemies, and from the hand of all that hate us; (72) To perform the mercy promised to our fathers, and to remember his holy covenant; (73) The oath which he sware to our father Abraham, (74) That he would grant unto us, that we being delivered out of the hand of our enemies might serve him without fear, (75) In holiness and righteousness before him, all the days of our life. (76) And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways; (77) To give knowledge of salvation unto his people by the remission of their sins, (78) Through the tender mercy of our God; whereby the dayspring from on high hath visited us, (79) To give light to them that sit in darkness and in the shadow of death, to guide our feet into the way of peace.

- Luk_2:14 Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will toward men.
- Luk_2:29 Lord, now lettest thou thy servant depart in peace, according to thy word:
- Luk_4:35 And Jesus rebuked him, saying, Hold thy peace, and come out of him. And when the devil had thrown him in the midst, he came out of him, and hurt him not.
- Luk_7:50 And he said to the woman, Thy faith hath saved thee; go in peace.

Luke 19:41-44 And when he was come near, he beheld the city, and wept over it, (42) Saying, If thou hadst known, even thou, at least in this thy day, the things which belong unto thy peace! but now they are hid from thine eyes. (43) For the days shall come upon thee, that thine enemies shall cast a trench about thee, and compass thee round, and keep thee in on every side, (44) And shall lay thee even with the ground, and thy children within thee; and they shall not leave in thee one stone upon another; because thou knewest not the time of thy visitation.

Luk_24:36 And as they thus spake, Jesus himself stood in the midst of them, and saith unto them, Peace be unto you.

¹¹ “Now, therefore, do Thou hearken unto us who pray unto Thee, and remember us the lowly and condemned, and turn again the captivity of our souls, having Thy loving-kindness interceding for us. Accept us who fall down before Thee and shout: We have sinned; on Thee were we cast from the womb, from our mother’s womb, Thou art our God.”

Recall Psalm 50: “For I know mine iniquity, and my sin is ever before me. Against Thee only have I sinned and done this evil before Thee, that Thou mightest be justified in Thy words, and prevail when Thou art judged. For behold, I was conceived in iniquities, and in sins did my mother bear me.”

This is a perfect example of the mindset of our prayers. We condemn ourselves and also hope --that is believe absolutely and wait for -the mercy of God. It takes little time for the Western mind to learn to pray like this and not to feel that it is wholly negative. Once you understand it, this prayer is bracing and cathartic and beautiful.

¹² This is reminiscent of the psalm: “As for transgressions, who will understand Them? From my secret sins cleanse me, ¹³ and from those of others spare Thy servant. If they have not dominion over me, then blameless shall I be, and I shall be cleansed from great sin. ¹⁴ And the sayings of my mouth shall be unto Thy good pleasure, and the meditation of my heart shall be before Thee forever, O Lord, my helper and redeemer. (Psalm 18:12-14)

¹³ “Measure our transgressions with Thy compassions, set the abyss of Thy compassions against the multitude of our sins.” This is worth pondering.

¹⁴ We must understand that we are continually being assaulted by the devil. He is constantly making suggestions to us and trying to manipulate us. Those that are weak and will or manipulated by him and then attack us. We should be aware that there is a great spiritual battle going on in every moment.

¹⁵ What is peace?
Mat_10:34 Think not that I am come to send peace on earth: I came not to send peace, but a sword.

Mar_4:39 And he arose, and rebuked the wind, and said unto the sea, Peace, be still. And the wind ceased, and there was a great calm.

Mar_9:50 Salt is good: but if the salt have lost his saltness, wherewith will ye season it? Have salt in yourselves, and have peace one with another.

Receive as an evening sacrifice the lifting up of our hands.

Vouchsafe us also to pass through the course of the night without blemish, untempted by evil.

And deliver us from every anxiety and fear that come to us from the devil.

Grant unto our souls compunction, and unto our thoughts solicitude concerning the trial at Thy dread and righteous judgement.

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An Evening Prayer of Supplication. From Kneeling Prayer 3.3.

O God, great and most high, Who alone hast immortality, and dwellest in light unapproachable;

Who hast fashioned all creation in wisdom;

Who hast divided the light from the darkness,⁶⁰ and hast set the sun for dominion of the day, the moon and stars for dominion of the night,

Who hast vouchsafed unto us sinners at this present hour to come before Thy presence with thanksgiving and to offer unto Thee evening doxology:

Nail our flesh with the fear of Thee, and mortify our earthly members,

that in the quietness of sleep we may be enlightened by the vision of Thy judgements.

Take from us every unseemly dream and pernicious carnal desire.

Raise us up at the hour of prayer fortified in faith and advancing in Thy commandments

do Thou Thyself, O Lover of mankind, direct our prayer as incense before Thee and accept it for a sweet-smelling savor; grant unto us that the present evening and the coming night be peaceful.

Clothe us with the armor of light. Deliver us from the terror by night and from everything that walketh in darkness.

And grant that the sleep which Thou hast given for the repose of our infirmity may be free from all fantasies of the devil.

Yea, O Master, Giver of good things,
may we, being moved to compunction
upon our beds,

remember Thy name in the night, and,
enlightened by meditation on Thy
commandments,

rise up in joyfulness of soul to the
glorification of Thy goodness, offering

prayers and supplications to Thy loving-
kindness for our own sins and for those
of all thy people,

whom do Thou visit in mercy, through
the intercessions of the most holy
Theotokos.

We believe that God's light is unapproachable and also that God can do anything that He wishes. And He has made it very clear to us that His great desire is for us to be illumined and enlightened and purified by his light. By His will, combined with our feeble efforts, we will become such that we can be in light and only known light, that is God.

⁵ God knows everything about us including what will happen. This is a great mystery, and some people are tripped up by it because they believe that if God already knows everything about us He has already arranged everything. This is a great snare that the devil gives us and we should not trip in it.

Since God knows everything about us, he is not surprised, and we are always protected by Him. The Psalms tell us: "My being while it was still unformed Thine eyes did see, and in Thy book shall all men be written;" (138:16), and Jesus assures us: "... Your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him." (Mat 6:8) The Christian who truly understands this has no anxiety.

⁶ This is very close to quoting the symbol of faith verbatim: "Who for us men, and for our salvation, came down from the heavens, and was incarnate of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, and became man."

⁷ I have taught many times that the Scripture is filled with questions. Even things that don't appear to be questions are questions we should answer. It is the same way with prayers. When the prayer says that Jesus Christ taught: "first in words and then in deeds," there is a question! The question is: "Do you teach only with words would you teach with words and deeds? Do you back up the things you say with who you are?"

⁸ Perhaps I will be corrected, but I know of no scripture where Jesus Christ specifically enjoins us to pray in this way, but the whole mind of the church understands this way of prayer. We understand that the priest, especially, is an intercessor for his people. This would be an example of our holy tradition, where a command is not written down but nevertheless is just as binding.

⁹ The phrase in the Kneeling prayer on Pentecost is: "hearken unto us in the day when we call upon Thee, and especially on this day of Pentecost"

¹⁰ The sending of the Holy Spirit was prophesied many times by Jesus Christ, and each time he told his disciples they did not understand. The Ascension of Christ was essential because otherwise the Holy Spirit would not have come. "Nevertheless I tell you the truth; It is expedient for you that I go away: for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I depart, I will send him unto you." John 16:7)

Jesus Christ referred to himself several times as "I am." This is one of the ways in which he declared that he was not only a man but also fully God, the only begotten son of God. The Jews certainly understood his claim, and hated them for it: ⁵⁸Jesus said to them, "Verily, verily, I say to you, before Abraham came to be, I am." ⁵⁹Then they took up stones that they might cast at Him; but Jesus was hidden, and went forth out of the temple, going through the midst of them, and so passed by." (John 8:28-59). Jesus also referred to Himself in this way when he was seen walking on the water, near the ship the disciples were in during a storm: "... Jesus spoke to them, saying, "Be of good courage, I am; cease being afraid." (Matthew 14:27)

We should ask ourselves, why would we be proud about our accomplishments – our intelligence or beauty or wealth or position in the world – when God has created us as we are, and only by His word and by His will do we continue to exist. We should not be proud, but very grateful that God has given us life. We also must understand that God has chosen to give man life and never to take it away.

Although man was created, after his creation God intended for man to live forever. Indeed, the soul once created never dies. The death that is spoken of in Genesis is separation and alienation from God because of sin. It is not the cessation of existence.

We should certainly not be afraid that God is going to blink us Out of existence, but we should also be very sure that all life comes from Him and anything not of Him is not life. That would mean that if we sin we should consider that to be a kind of death. There are many things in this world that appear to be alive, but they are dead because they are not of God. The true Christian, whose heart is directed towards God and desires to be alive in him, will learn to recognize the things that are alive and the things that are dead.

⁴ When a person says that God "dwellest in light unapproachable", he is speaking about a dogma about God: "God is light and in Him is no darkness at all (1 John 1:5). The light of God is the uncreated light, the same that was seen by the three apostles on Mount Tabor. This light is eternal, because God is eternal. Another Way of referring to the light is: "God's energies."

One of the major differences between Eastern Orthodoxy and any Western confession of Christianity is that we know dogmatically that we can experience God through His energies, His light. This is only possible for those who have been purified because the light is purifying. The light is enlightening. We learn about God by being united to God, and becoming like him. One could say that salvation is for us to become a lesser light as God is light. And in that light, there would be no darkness at all.

Appendix: Useful short prayers excerpted from the Kneeling Prayers

These excerpts could be included in any rule of prayer.

Short Intercessions for all the dead.

Hearken unto us that pray unto Thee, and grant rest to the souls of Thy servants, our fathers and brethren departed before us, and the rest of our kindred according to the flesh, and all our fellow-believers, ... for Thou hast dominion over all, and upholdest in Thy hand all the ends of the earth. From Kneeling Prayer 3.1

Accept, O Master, our prayers and supplications, and give rest unto all the fathers and mothers and children and the brothers and sisters and relatives of each one of us, and all the souls gone to their rest before us; and commit their spirits unto the hope of resurrection unto life eternal, and inscribe their names in the Book of Life, in the bosom of Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, in the land of the living, in the Kingdom of Heaven, in the Paradise of delight, by Thy radiant angels bringing all into Thy holy habitations. From Kneeling Prayer 3.2

O God, do Thou hearken unto us who pray unto Thee, and remember us the lowly and condemned, and turn again the captivity of our souls, having Thy loving-kindness interceding for us. Accept us who fall down before Thee and shout: We have sinned; on Thee were we cast from the womb, from our mother's womb, Thou art our God
From Kneeling Prayer 1.1

O God, attend to us through Thy good favour and grace; measure our transgressions with Thy compassions, set the abyss of Thy compassions against the multitude of our sins. ... , behold, in fear I stand before Thee, having cast the despair of my soul into the abyss of Thy mercy. From Kneeling Prayer 1.1 and 2.2

O God, cleanse us by the working of Thy Holy Spirit; destroy the wiles of the enemy directed against us. From Kneeling Prayer 1.1

O God, as Thou art a good and man-loving God,⁶¹ loose, remit, and pardon our transgressions, voluntary and involuntary, whether in knowledge or in ignorance, manifest and forgotten, whether in deed or thought or word, in all our lives and ways. From Kneeling Prayer 3.2

¹ All of the Kneeling Vespers prayers, with small editing changes (recognized by "..." or *italics* to make the prayers flow better for daily, personal prayer.

This document is at: <http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost-for-personal-prayer.doc>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost-for-personal-prayer.pdf>

The full text of the Prayers is at: <http://www.orthodox.net/services/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost.doc>

<http://www.orthodox.net/services/kneeling-prayers-of-pentecost.pdf>

This document can be printed as is, or made into a booklet, with software such as "Clickbook"

The endnotes are designed to be used when teaching these prayers in catechesis classes. Our theology is open, and accessible to everyone, in our prayers. Those who are Orthodox, and those who want to learn about Orthodox Christianity, must study the prayers of the church AND PRAY THEM to understand the church.

² The beginning of this prayer can be understood as a confession of faith, and the survey of the nature of God and the incarnation. It can be thought of as a compunctionate, more detailed explanation of certain parts of the Nicene Creed. It should be studied carefully.

An important aspect of Orthodox prayer is that **our prayer is deeply theological and dogmatic**. For us, dogma is a living thing not just facts. That God is and all things concerning his nature and the dual nature of the God man Jesus Christ is for us first and foremost the most important knowledge in the world. Our prayer is constantly suffused with expressions of these dogmas. Of course, dogma is no use whatsoever to the soul unless we change our behavior and it guides the way we live our lives

³ Man and the angels are immortal, but they have a beginning. They were all created when we refer to the immortality of God we refer to someone who always was and is, and has no beginning or ending. In the Scriptures God refers to himself when asked for His name as "I am". He is the only self-existent being in the universe. All existence comes through him. By His will alone does anything exist and continue to exist. This is a fundamental dogma, derived from God's nature and his activity in the world.